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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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Surrogates for ‘DOGE’ scouring agencies

Outside effort to shrink government takes hold before Trump’s return

BY FAIZ SIDDIQUI, JEFF STEIN AND ELIZABETH DWOSKIN

Elon Musk and Vivek Ramaswamy are sending representatives to agencies across the federal government, four people familiar with the matter said, to begin preliminary interviews that will shape the tech executives’ enormous ambitions to tame Washington’s sprawling bureaucracy.

In recent days, aides with the nongovernmental “Department of Government Efficiency” tied to President-elect Donald Trump’s transition team have spoken with staffers at more than a dozen federal agencies, said the people, who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak with the media. The agencies include the Treasury Department, the Internal Revenue Service and the departments of Homeland Security, Veterans Affairs, and Health and Human Services, the people said.

At the same time, Musk and Ramaswamy have significantly stepped up hiring for their new entity, with more than 50 staffers already working out of the offices of SpaceX, Musk’s rocket-building company, in downtown Washington, two of the people said. DOGE aims to have a staff of close to 100 people in place by Trump’s inauguration on Jan. 20, they said.

While much about DOGE
SEE **DOGE** ON A4

In parting blow, Biden goes after Russian oil

Sweeping sanctions are bid to pressure Moscow and hurt its war effort

BY KAREN DEYOUNG

The Biden administration delivered a parting blow to Russia’s economy Friday, targeting two of its largest oil companies and 183 oil tankers in what a senior official called the “most significant sanctions yet against the Russian energy sector, the largest source of revenue for the Kremlin’s war machine.”

The sweeping new sanctions also include measures against a long list of other entities involved in virtually all sectors of Russia’s energy business, along with what officials described as a “narrowing” of the U.S. Treasury Department license that has allowed Russia to be paid in dollars for its energy exports.

The sanctions announcement followed the release in recent weeks of billions more dollars’ worth of U.S. military assistance for Kyiv as President Joe Biden seeks to solidify his legacy in defense of Ukraine and lay the groundwork for continued

SEE **RUSSIA** ON A12

In Syria: International sanctions put health system on the brink. **A8**

Trump becomes first president to be sentenced



JABIN BOTSFORD/THE WASHINGTON POST

Donald Trump and attorney Todd Blanche appear virtually from Florida for the president-elect’s sentencing in Manhattan on Friday. Trump was convicted last year on 34 felony counts of falsifying business records related to payments to adult-film actress Stormy Daniels.

NO JAIL, PROBATION OR FINE IN N.Y. CASE

He continues to condemn hush money proceedings

BY SHAYNA JACOBS, DEREK HAWKINS AND MARK BERMAN

NEW YORK — President-elect Donald Trump received no penalty Friday for his conviction in his hush money trial, an extraordinary moment that saw him become the first U.S. president sentenced for a crime.

The sentencing hearing — held just 10 days before Trump is to be inaugurated for a second term — reflected the history and affirmed that Trump would be the first president to enter office as a felon.

Trump, sometimes scowling or looking away, appeared on a screen from Florida as New York Supreme Court Justice Juan Merchan spoke about the difficulty of sentencing the incoming president.

“Never before has this court been presented with such a unique and remarkable set of circumstances,” Merchan said.

Trump, who was convicted on 34 felony counts of falsifying business records last year, had furiously sought to cancel the sentencing, appealing to the U.S. Supreme Court and arguing that it would

SEE **TRUMP** ON A4

Supreme Court appears poised to uphold TikTok ban-or-sale law

BY ANN E. MARIMOW

The Supreme Court on Friday appeared likely to uphold a federal law that would effectively shut down TikTok in the United States in less than two weeks unless the popular video-sharing platform divests from Chinese ownership.

A majority of justices from across the ideological spectrum suggested during more than 2½ hours of oral arguments that the government’s interest in national security justified some restrictions on free speech. They particularly seemed to embrace Congress’s concern about the Chinese government covertly using the app to collect vast amounts of sensitive data about

Justices more concerned about national security than harm to free speech

millions of American users and potentially exploiting that information to blackmail young Americans or turn them into spies.

Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr. asked the lawyer representing TikTok about Chinese government influence over TikTok’s parent company ByteDance: “Are we supposed to ignore the fact that the ultimate parent is, in fact, subject to doing intelligence work for the Chinese govern-

ment?”

“That seems like a huge concern for the future of the country,” Justice Brett M. Kavanaugh later added.

The company and a group of TikTok creators had asked the justices to quickly block the law before the Jan. 19 deadline that Congress set for China-based ByteDance to sell the platform, which has more than 170 million users in the United States. The court’s decision could have implications beyond TikTok for how aggressively the U.S. government can set rules for the social media platforms more and more

SEE **TIKTOK** ON A2

Legal loopholes: Many could find ways to use TikTok after a ban. **A11**

Altadena at the abyss: ‘No one has a home’

The scope of tragedy and loss from L.A. wildfires is slowly coming into focus

BY JOSHUA PARTLOW

ALTADENA, CALIF. — Maral Nazarian has been waking at night thinking about what she could have saved.

Family passports. Important files. The toddler art of her two grown daughters. The 59-year-old travel agent evacuated her home in sweatpants and a T-shirt on the night of the fire — not in a panic, but because she had every intention to return.

She loved it here in Altadena, below the dry hills on the outskirts of Los Angeles, and was savvy about fire. It had always stayed far enough away. Now its handiwork lay before her — the family home, and all it saw, blackened, twisted and gone.

“My husband’s brother lost his

house. We lost our house. My husband’s partner lost his house,” she said Thursday. “No one has a home.”

The mind-bending scale of residential ruin from the multiple Los Angeles fires is slowly coming into focus. Officials said Friday that about 7,000 structures had been damaged or destroyed in the Altadena area, a community of 42,000 people.

“I will tell you it looks like a war zone. I’ve never seen anything like it,” Kathryn Barger, a Los Angeles County supervisor, said at a Friday news conference.

On text chains and social media neighborhood groups, Altadena residents have been commiserating about their losses — the historic homes and family businesses, parks and shops, churches and mosques that have been

SEE **ALTADENA** ON A6

Overview: Six fires burn in region as death toll rises to 11. **A5**

Anger at mayor: L.A.’s Karen Bass is also facing a political crisis. **A5**

Officials say conditions went beyond limits of firefighting

BY SCOTT DANCE

The fire in the hills above the Pacific Palisades was a monster from the start, spanning the size of 150 football fields within half an hour and an area larger than Manhattan a day after that. It would take four days before firefighters could establish even a short line of containment around it.

And yet, well before the Palisades Fire ignited Tuesday morning, preparations had begun for aggressive firefighting. Based on forecasts of dangerously fierce and dry Santa Ana winds across Southern California, the Los Angeles Fire Department that morning readied more than a dozen extra engines — mostly in high-risk locations to the north, in the

San Fernando Valley — along with the 98 it keeps at the ready in its stations.

The blaze quickly outmatched anything they were ready to handle. LAFD took the rare step of recalling all of its off-duty firefighters for service, while also gathering crews from departments across Southern California. When hurricane-force wind gusts prevented firefighting by air on Tuesday and early Wednesday, crews worked from the ground by the hundreds, helping people escape and scrambling to protect whatever property they could. But they could do nothing to stop the flames.

Some frightened and angry Angelenos have criticized the firefighting response after re-

SEE **FIRES** ON A7

IN THE NEWS

‘Havana syndrome’ Two intelligence agencies now say it’s possible some of the mysterious ailments were due to a foreign adversary. **A10**

12½-year sentence A former worker at the D.C. department of parks and recreation faces prison time for the fatal shooting of an unarmed 13-year-old. **B1**

THE NATION

A plea from the suspected mastermind of 9/11 was blocked by an appeals court. **A3**
Prosecutors sought at least 15 years for former senator Bob Menendez, convicted of bribery. **A3**

THE WORLD

Venezuelan strongman Nicolás Maduro was sworn in, despite his disputed election. **A9**
Ukraine’s leader is turning to alternative U.S. media outlets to reach Republicans. **A10**

THE ECONOMY

A free app has become a valuable source of information for Los Angeles residents seeking information on fast-moving wildfires. **A11**
The U.S. economy added 256,000 jobs in December despite higher-than-normal interest rates. **A12**

THE REGION

Municipalities in the region are preparing for more snow amid persistent challenges to clear non-primary roads. **B1**
The attorney general in D.C. is suing the federal government for dumping dangerous chemical waste into the Anacostia River. **B1**

STYLE

Rep. Sarah McBride, a freshman, has an agenda, but it’s not what you may think. **C1**

SPORTS

Ohio State delivers a dagger against Texas on a fourth-and-goal fumble return touchdown at the Cotton Bowl on its way to a 28-14 win. **D1**

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